

come back the next day.” I’m 21 years old, in a new city where I don’t know anyone, and I am being told that I will be fired every day. It was a bit unsettling.

On the first day, I was thrown into the fire. I knew absolutely nothing. My boss was hand signaling me from the pit. I didn’t know the hand signals yet; I had to learn them from a sheet they handed you. We go back to the office after the first day of work, and he says, “My account is off by 20 lots. Get the hell out of my office, and don’t come back. You’re fired.”

What did you do?

I came in to the office the next morning, tail between my legs, and sat down at the desk. He didn’t say anything and acted as if everything was normal. And then two days later he says, “You don’t know what you’re doing. You’re fired.”

During those first few days, did you think that maybe you didn’t want to do this? It sounds like a miserable job.

[He laughs hard.] It was miserable.

Did things get any better?

No, it was definitely a bad period of time. He really needed an experienced clerk. After six months we reached a mutual decision that I should leave. I took an easier job as a runner on the floor.

After working for about a year as a runner, I got a trading position for a firm run by Steve Fossett, the famous world adventurer. The deal was that you would put up \$10,000 of your own money, and the firm supplemented it with \$15,000. You kept all the profits on your own portion of the funds and 60 percent of the profits on the firm’s capital. The firm supplied you with an exchange seat for which you paid a monthly rental fee.

What had you learned that made you think you could make money as a trader?

Not much. To be frank, I didn’t have a handle on what to do. I was just making bets. I just thought I could do it. What’s funny is that I remember